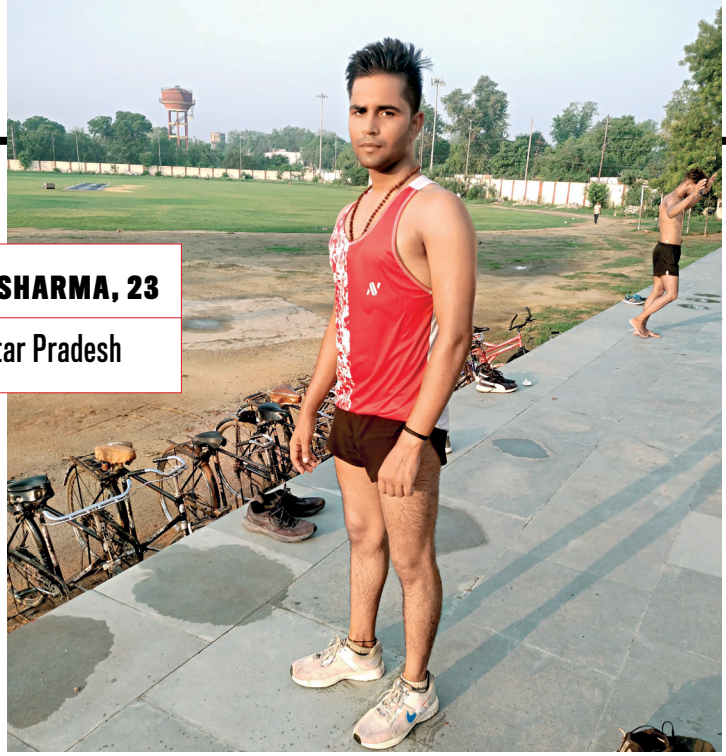


LALIT KUMAR

MOHIT SHARMA, 23

Agra, Uttar Pradesh

'Written test never happened'

Mohit Sharma, 23, was an athlete in school but his big dream was to join the Indian Army. Watching war movies or military films is still his favourite pastime. The son of a temporary clerk at Agra tehsil, his first cousin is currently serving in the army. But, now he is overage and can't join the Agniveers. He blames the authorities for the mess. "I applied for the army when I was 21, cleared the physical and medical tests and was told that I would be soon called for a written test. But, the written test never happened and now I am out of the race," he says.

Mohit says many of his friends are in a similar situation. No one told them that their physical and medical tests could become null and void. They were always given administrative reasons for delays in organising the written test. Mohit's father earns Rs, 15,000 a month and they pledged their only property to get a loan to fund Mohit's course at a defence coaching academy in Lucknow for over a year.

In the case of the army, at least two batches of recruits were waiting for the written exams after having completed their physical/ medical tests. The Indian Army recruits jawans under 13 categories, including tradesmen and technical.

'unaffected' by the Agnipath scheme. The petitioners claim the timeline for the completion of the process was a year but now stands delayed by 2.5 years because of Covid and unexplained administrative reasons posted on the board's official website.

Advocate Kumud Lata Das, appearing for the group of 33, says, "The CASB issued various updates regarding the delays in recruitment but the failure to give a clear reason for it has caused damage to my clients." More than the huge expenses on coaching and money spent to travel for the physical and interview, Sonu is vexed about the three years lost after they cleared the test. "And with the new Agnipath scheme, we have to go through the whole process again," he told INDIA TODAY over the phone.

Inder Singh's story has taken the same trajectory. Hailing from a small village in Nagaur district of Rajasthan, the 20-year-old son of a driver had ranked high in the pre-selection list. After his 12th, he had moved to Jaipur for coaching to prepare for the armed forces. He cleared the airmen's test on the first attempt, his family rejoicing that he would be the first in the clan to join the armed force. "After our selection process, we were repeatedly given assurances by the authorities that the delays were temporary. At no point were we given the impression that our selection would be rejected," says Inder Singh.

While empathising with the candidates, IAF officials maintain that the air force cannot now recruit people through two different schemes. IAF spokesperson Wing Commander Ashish Moge maintains that since no call letter was issued, the process was not complete. "If they were capable of clearing the [airmen] test then, they can do so now as the selection process has not changed," he says. Lt Gen. Puri concurs. "Though they have done the selection process, a final merit list was not prepared. Now they can only come in through the Agnipath scheme."

The recruitment was to be done in multiple phases, which consisted of an online test, physical fitness test, group discussion, adaptability tests and a medical examination. While the final list consists of at least 65 per cent of candidates in the provisional selection list, the majority of petitioners have high ranking therefore in all probability their appointment was certain. However, the aspirants argue that while in 2020, the entry for officers through the National Defence Academy (NDA) and Combined Defence Services (CDS) exams were on, authorities resorted to excuses to delay recruitment of jawans.

Rashtriya Loktantrik Party founder Hanuman Beniwal, the MP from Nagaur, Rajasthan, met the defence minister Rajnath Singh in April. "I was assured by Rajnath that those who have gone through the selection pro-